LOC, he explains, because they believed that doing so would yield "political gains with the world community." "We had to get the world to accept that this was Pakistan's fault." Staying on its side of the LOC enabled India to "keep the moral high ground."[68]

Despite these concerns, Indian leaders would probably have crossed the line of control if doing so had proved to be necessary. According to Malik, the civilian leadership's "overriding political goal . . . was to eject the intruders." The government made clear that it would revisit its policy if military leaders ever felt the need to cross the LOC. This did not occur because the Indians quickly began winning at Kargil and by early June were confident of victory. However, Malik maintains that "if the tactical situation had not gone well, India would have crossed the LOC," regardless of Pakistan's nuclear capacity. Pakistan had just shown that attacks across the line of control need not trigger nuclear escalation. Thus the Indians believed that Kargil could also be "done the other way."[69]

Former Indian national security adviser Brajesh Mishra offers a similar analysis. "The army never pushed the government to cross" the LOC, he explains. "If the army had wanted, the government would have considered crossing." Mishra maintains that Pakistan's nuclear capacity would not have deterred the cabinet from granting the army's request, since Pakistan would have been unlikely to use nuclear weapons in that scenario. "Pakistan can be finished by a few bombs," Mishra argues. "Anyone with a small degree of sanity would know that [nuclear war] would have disastrous consequences for Pakistan."[70]

Former defense minister George Fernandes supports these claims. According to Fernandes, India did not need to violate the line of control. Once the Indian counteroffensive got under way, the government was convinced that "India was in control [and] did not believe that the tactical situation was going to deteriorate." Simultaneously, the Pakistanis were suffering an international backlash, with "the United States . . . pressuring Pakistan" to undo the Kargil incursions.[71]

Former prime minister Atal Behari Vajpayee concurs with these assessments. "There was no need to cross the LOC," he explains, "because militarily India was successful. But nothing was ruled out. If